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Nina, too young to have the 'bald' white head, is released by Mathias Engelmann

Bald Eagle



Bald Eagle Flies Home To The Wilds

By **BARBARA BARNETT**
Staff Writer

BADIN — Nina's liberation came at 11 Tuesday morning.

The American bald eagle spread her brown and gold wings and soared into the icy wind. She glided majestically above the barren gray trees, above the rocky, broom sedge-covered hills, over the glistening blue water of Falls Lake and into the Uwharrie National Forest.

"I guess the words 'sun god' came into my mind," said Richard Brown, executive director of the Carolina Raptor Center Inc.

Nina flew away after almost three months at the Raptor Center, at Latta Plantation Park in Mecklenburg County. The eagle, whose wingspan measures 7 feet, was taken to the center Dec. 5 to recuperate from a gunshot wound.

A state wildlife official discovered the injured bird Nov. 23 in Johnston County, southeast of Raleigh. A .22-caliber rifle bullet hit her wing and lodged in her thigh. She was taken to a Cary veterinarian, then to the Raptor Center.

Shooting a bald eagle, an endangered species, carries a maximum penalty of \$20,000 fine and a year in jail. Brown said as many as 20 to 40 bald eagles have been sighted in North Carolina in recent years.

Nina is the first bald eagle the Raptor Center has released into the wild. She arrived in Badin after a 75-minute trip in the backseat of the Raptor Center's jeep, in the arms of volunteer Mathias Engelmann.

"It's kind of sad, but I'm glad she's out there where she belongs," he said.

When Engelmann released Nina, she flew a few hundred yards, then alighted on a log.

After about five minutes of orientation, she flew into the forest. And a half-hour later, the 20 bird

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Center director Richard Brown watches



Staff Photos By **DON STURKEY**

Nina heads out, over Falls Lake